

QUEENS COLLEGE
CITY UNIVERSITY OF NEW YORK

Education Unit

Department of Educational and Community Programs

Graduate Programs in Special Education

ECPSE 729 — Ethics and Professionalism in Applied Behavior Analysis (3 credits)

Summer 2026 · Asynchronous · 4 Weeks

Instructor: Dr. Lenwood Gibson

E-mail: lenwood.gibson@qc.cuny.edu

Office: 032M Powdermaker Hall

Office Hours: Mondays, 7:00–8:00 PM ET via Zoom · by appointment only (email to book a slot; Zoom link in Brightspace)

Response time: Within 24 hours for email, including weekends. Grading/discussion replies within 72 hours of submission.

Course Portals

Course Site (lectures, resources, Edpuzzle): <https://lgibs222.github.io/ecpse729-summer2026/>

Edpuzzle class (join link for the embedded knowledge checks): <https://edpuzzle.com/join/gipibau>

Brightspace: system of record for submissions, discussions, grades.

I. Course Description

This course is offered to graduate students in special education who are also pursuing their Board Certified Behavior Analyst (BCBA) certification. Candidates who take this course must have already successfully completed ECPSE 723 Applied Behavior Analysis I and ECPSE 728 Applied Behavior Analysis II.

ECPSE 729 prepares candidates for the ethical and professional practice of applied behavior analysis. The course is built around the 2022 BACB Ethics Code for Behavior Analysts. Topics include responsibility as a professional; responsibility in practice (effective treatment, assent, minimizing harm); responsibility to clients, stakeholders, supervisees, and trainees; responsibility in public statements and on social media; responsibility in research; the BACB Code-Enforcement Procedures; and the disciplinary infrastructure that holds the field accountable. Throughout, the course engages seriously with the autistic self-advocacy critique of ABA — not to defend the field or to abandon it, but to ask what the Code requires of us when the people we serve tell us we have been wrong.

Asynchronous delivery means students engage with course content on their own schedule each week. Each module opens Sunday at 12:01 AM and closes the following Sunday at 11:59 PM. Plan ~6–10 hours of focused work per week.

II. Relationship of this Course to the Education Unit's Conceptual Framework

Queens College is located in the diverse urban community of Flushing, in the New York City Borough of Queens. This course is aligned with the Core Values of the Education Unit of “promoting Equity,

Excellence, and Ethics in urban schools and communities.” More specifically, the Education Unit is committed to preparing teachers and educational professionals who:

- Build inclusive communities that nurture and challenge all learners (Equity)
- Demonstrate professionalism, scholarship, efficacy, and evidence-based and reflective practice (Excellence)
- Value diversity, democracy, and social justice (Ethics)

Through the exploration of the principles and practices of applied behavior analysis specifically as they relate to supporting instruction and classroom management of students with disabilities in general and special education settings, this seminar also embeds the 7 Content Standards established jointly by the Council for the Accreditation of Educator Preparation (CAEP) and the Council for Exceptional Children (CEC):

- Learner Development and Individual Learning Differences
- Learning Environments
- Curricular Content Knowledge
- Assessment
- Instructional Planning and Strategies
- Professional Learning and Practice
- Collaboration

III. Course Competencies

All candidates upon successful completion of ECPSE 729 will have developed and demonstrated the following knowledge, skills, and dispositions related to applied behavior analysis. Each competency maps to the BCBA 6th edition Test Content Outline (TCO).

#	ECPSE 729 Course Competency (Knowledge, Skills & Dispositions)	Education Unit Core Values	BCBA 6th TCO
1.	Understand the Behavior Analyst Certification Board's Core Principles, application of the Code, and enforcement of the Code	<i>Ethics, Excellence, Equity</i>	E-6
2.	Understand the history of ethical principles in behavioral science (Sunland, Willowbrook, Van Houten et al., 1988) and the lineage that produced the BACB	<i>Ethics, Equity</i>	—
3.	Understand and demonstrate ethical and professional behavior according to the 2022 Code	<i>Ethics, Excellence, Equity</i>	E-10
4.	Understand and demonstrate Responsibility as a Professional (Section 1.0)	<i>Ethics, Equity, Excellence</i>	E-1
5.	Understand and demonstrate Responsibility in Practice — effective treatment, assent, minimizing risk (Section 2.0)	<i>Ethics, Equity</i>	E-2, E-3, E-4
6.	Understand and demonstrate Responsibility to Clients and Stakeholders — service agreements, third-party contracts, continuity (Section 3.0)	<i>Ethics, Equity</i>	E-2, E-3, E-4

7.	Understand and demonstrate Responsibility to Supervisees and Trainees — accountability, evidence-based supervision (Section 4.0)	<i>Excellence, Ethics, Equity</i>	E-5
8.	Understand and demonstrate Responsibility in Public Statements — including social media and digital practice (Section 5.0)	<i>Excellence, Ethics, Equity</i>	E-6, E-7, E-8
9.	Understand and demonstrate Responsibility in Research — informed consent, publication integrity (Section 6.0)	<i>Excellence, Ethics, Equity</i>	E-9
10.	Engage seriously with autistic self-advocacy critiques of ABA and translate the engagement into changed clinical practice	<i>Ethics, Equity, Excellence</i>	—
11.	Reason about emerging digital practice — telehealth, AI-assisted clinical work, social media — under a Code that was written before most of these tools were in widespread use	<i>Excellence, Ethics</i>	—

Anthology ePortfolio

The Education Unit uses Anthology as an electronic portfolio and assessment system. When candidates are admitted to one of the undergraduate or graduate programs in the Education Unit, they will be required to register for an Anthology ePortfolio subscription to submit their assignments as directed until graduation. Faculty will assess all key program assignments submitted by candidates in Anthology. The electronic portfolio system is not used to assess for grading purposes.

Do NOT register for an Anthology subscription until you are specifically asked to do so by your instructor.

IV. Required Text and Supplemental Readings

No required textbook. This course uses Open Educational Resources.

Required Readings (free / open access):

- Behavior Analyst Certification Board. (2020). *Ethics code for behavior analysts*. (effective January 2022). <https://www.bacb.com/wp-content/uploads/2020/11/Ethics-Code-for-Behavior-Analysts-2102010.pdf>
- Behavior Analyst Certification Board. (2020). *BACB code-enforcement procedures*. https://www.bacb.com/wp-content/uploads/2020/05/BACB-Code-Enforcement-Procedures_210127.pdf
- Van Houten, R., Axelrod, S., Bailey, J. S., Favell, J. E., Foxx, R. M., Iwata, B. A., & Lovaas, I. (1988). The right to effective behavioral treatment. *Journal of Applied Behavior Analysis*, 21(4), 381–384.

Engagement-with-the-Critique Readings (M02):

- Morris, C., Detrick, J. J., & Peterson, S. M. (2021). Participant assent in behavior-analytic research and practice. *Journal of Applied Behavior Analysis*, 54(4), 1373–1388.
- Sandoval-Norton, A. H., Shkedy, G., & Shkedy, D. (2019). How much compliance is too much compliance: Is long-term ABA therapy abuse? *Cogent Psychology*, 6(1), 1641258.

V. Course Performance-Based Assessment Measures

1. Lecture Module Knowledge Checks (10 points total · 2.5 pts × 4 modules)

Each week opens with an instructor-built lecture (16–29 min, with embedded knowledge checks delivered via Edpuzzle). The four lectures, collectively, walk every numbered Section of the 2022 Code plus the Code-Enforcement Procedures. Each lecture has 8 knowledge checks (32 KCs total across the course). Completion of all 8 KCs in a given lecture earns 2.5 points for that week. Watch each lecture in the assigned week.

2. Decision-Making Labs (20 points total · 5 pts × 4 modules)

Each week, candidates apply the BACB 11-step decision-making model to an assigned scenario. The response is recorded as a 5–7 minute Brightspace Discussion Video. Scenarios are designed to activate the Code sections covered that week. The grading rubric (provided in Brightspace) evaluates: (a) facts and stakeholders, (b) Code citations, (c) Core Principles framing, (d) three or more courses of action with mapped consequences, (e) selected action with rationale, and (f) reflection on personal biases (per Code 1.10).

3. Practitioner Ethics Toolkit (16 points total)

Across the course, candidates build a four-artifact Practitioner Ethics Toolkit they take into fieldwork. Each artifact is a 1-page (Toolkit 4: 1–2 pages) document graded Met / Approaching / Not Yet. Templates are provided in Brightspace.

- Toolkit 1 (M01) — Scope-of-Competence Map · 2 pts
- Toolkit 2 (M02) — Assent-Monitoring Protocol · 2 pts
- Toolkit 3 (M03) — Social Media + Digital Practice Policy · 2 pts
- Toolkit 4 (M04, CAPSTONE) — Your Personal Code of Practice · 10 pts

The capstone (Toolkit 4) synthesizes the course into a Code of Practice that is the candidate's — the document they'd hand a future employer, fieldwork supervisee, or skeptical parent. Required components: professional identity statement, non-negotiables tied to specific Codes, daily practices, gray-case framework, one commitment per module, and "what I've changed my mind about."

4. Weekly Discussions (12 points total · 3 pts × 4 modules)

Each module has a substantive discussion thread paired with the week's required resources:

- M01 — Podcast + Brightspace Video Discussion (3 pts)
- M02 — Critique Engagement (Sandoval-Norton + autistic self-advocacy reading) Video Discussion (3 pts)
- M03 — Restraint Engagement Position Video (3 pts)
- M04 — Disciplinary Patterns Analysis Video Discussion (3 pts)

Each requires a 2–3 minute video post plus substantive replies to at least two classmates.

5. External Video Edpuzzle Engagement (12 points total · 2 pts × 6 videos)

Each week's required external videos (Willowbrook documentaries, JABA / Inside the BACB / Behavioral Observations panels) are delivered through Edpuzzle with 2–3 open-ended prompts per video. Completion earns 2 points per video.

6. Final Ethical Scenarios Video Presentation — CAPSTONE (10 points; due M03)

Each candidate is assigned one ethical scenario from the bank of 10 at the start of M01. The scenario is developed across Modules 1–3, with the final 5–7 minute Brightspace Discussion Video due Sunday of M03. The rubric (provided in Brightspace) evaluates: (a) scenario summary, (b) Code analysis across at least Sections 1.0, 2.0, 3.0, and 4.0 or 5.0, (c) Core Principles framing, (d) three or more courses of action with one centering the stakeholder whose voice is hardest to hear, (e) selected action with rationale grounded in the course's frames, and (f) self-reflection. 7 points for the video analysis + 3 points for two substantive peer reviews.

7. Practitioner Interview Report — CAPSTONE (4 points; due M04)

Each candidate conducts a 30–45 minute interview with a practicing BCBA (at least three years post-credential) about a real ethical situation from their practice. Required deliverables: signed consent form (template provided in Brightspace), interview questions, and a 2-page reflective report covering the situation, the competing considerations, the decision, the aftermath, and the interviewee's advice for a new BCBA. The recording is deleted within 30 days of the assignment due date per the consent agreement.

8. Course Site Async Engagement (16 points total · 4 pts × 4 weeks)

Engagement with the public course site (<https://lgibs222.github.io/ecpse729-summer2026/>) and Brightspace throughout the week. This is the asynchronous-attendance equivalent — completed by hitting all the required weekly milestones and demonstrating engagement with peers in discussion threads. 4 points per week, distributed across Modules 1–4.

VI. Course Grading

Grades are assigned based on the total points earned across the performance-based assessment measures in relation to mastery of the course competencies. The full distribution:

Performance-Based Assessment Components	Points
Lecture Module Knowledge Checks (4 × 2.5 pts via Edpuzzle)	10
Decision-Making Labs (4 × 5 pts; Brightspace Video Discussion)	20
Practitioner Ethics Toolkit — Artifacts 1, 2, 3 (3 × 2 pts)	6
Practitioner Ethics Toolkit 4 — Personal Code of Practice (CAPSTONE)	10
Weekly Discussions (4 × 3 pts)	12
External Video Edpuzzle Engagement (6 × 2 pts)	12
Final Ethical Scenarios Video Presentation + Peer Reviews (CAPSTONE, M03)	10

Practitioner Interview Report (CAPSTONE, M04)	4
Course Site Async Engagement (4 weeks × 4 pts)	16
TOTAL	100

Letter Grade Scale

A+	97–100% of pts.
A	94–96% of pts.
A–	90–93% of pts.
B+	87–89% of pts.
B	84–86% of pts.
B–	80–83% of pts.
C	70–79% of pts.
F	69% of pts. and below

VII. Special Notes

All candidates are expected to have email access for communication with the instructor outside of class. Personal, individual meetings with the instructor can be arranged via the Monday 7–8 PM Zoom office-hour block (by appointment only — email to book). The class schedule is tentative; to individualize instruction, the instructor may revise topics or assignments. All candidates are expected to keep a copy of any assignments submitted.

Late Submission Policy

For each calendar day an assignment is submitted late, a 10% reduction in the overall assignment grade is applied. If an assignment is more than 5 days late, the candidate automatically receives a zero for that assignment.

Use of Generative AI (GenAI)

Candidates may use generative AI tools (ChatGPT, Claude, etc.) to support brainstorming, outlining, and editing — but all submitted work must be candidate-authored, including the ethical reasoning in Decision Lab videos, the Final Scenarios Video, and Toolkit artifacts. AI-generated text presented as the candidate’s own analysis is a violation of academic integrity and of BACB Ethics Code Standard 1.01 (Being Truthful). Candidates are expected to disclose AI use in a one-line statement at the top of any written submission (e.g., “AI assistance: Claude used for outline review only; all analysis and writing is my own”). When in doubt, ask.

Communication Norms

Course-content questions should be posted in the Brightspace Q&A discussion (your classmates likely have the same question). Email the instructor directly for anything personal or time-sensitive. Office-hour appointments are booked via email.

VIII. CUNY Policy on Academic Integrity

Academic dishonesty is prohibited in The City University of New York and is punishable by penalties, including failing grades, suspension, and expulsion as provided at:

<http://qcpages.qc.cuny.edu/provost/policies/index.html>

IX. Reasonable Accommodations for Candidates with Disabilities

Candidates with disabilities needing academic accommodation should: (1) register with and provide documentation to the QC Office of Special Services (<https://www.qc.cuny.edu/sp/>); (2) forward an accommodation letter to the instructor by end of Week 1. Don't wait until Week 4 — most accommodations work best when set up early. For platform / Brightspace / video-playback issues, contact QC's Center for Excellence in Teaching, Learning, and Leadership (<https://www.qc.cuny.edu/cetll/>) first; they're faster than the instructor for platform issues.

X. Use of Candidate Work

All teacher education programs in New York State undergo periodic reviews by accreditation agencies and the state education department. For these purposes, samples of candidates' work are made available to professionals conducting the review. Anonymity is assured. If you do not wish to have your work made available for these purposes, please let the instructor know before the start of the second week.

XI. Faculty Responsibility for Course Outline

This course was developed by Dr. Lenwood Gibson.

XII. Tentative Schedule

Each module opens Sunday at 12:01 AM and closes the following Sunday at 11:59 PM. All assignments due Sunday 11:59 PM of the listed week. Detailed module pages (resources, due dates, links) are on the course site at lgibs222.github.io/ecpse729-summer2026.

Date	Topic(s)	Required Engagement / Assignments
Week 1 6/1/2026 (Mon)	Module 01 opens — Foundations & The Self as Ethical Practitioner Section 1.0 (16 codes) · Core Principles · BACB 11-step decision model	— Watch Lecture Module 1 (28:45, 8 KCs) — Willowbrook: Path Forward (YouTube + Edpuzzle) — Unforgotten: 25 Years After Willowbrook (YouTube + Edpuzzle)
Week 1 6/2–6/6/2026	Required external resources	— Podcast: Inside the BACB Ep. 6 — History of Ethics — Podcast: Inside the BACB Ep. 15 — Introduction to the 2022 Ethics Code — Podcast: Behavioral Observations / Inside JABA Series 12 — Cultural Responsiveness in ABA — Reading: Van Houten et al. (1988) — Right to Effective Behavioral Treatment
Week 1 6/7/2026 (Sun)	Module 01 closes — All M01 assignments due 11:59 PM	— Decision Lab 1 (5 pts) · Toolkit 1 — Scope-of-Competence Map (2 pts) · Lecture Module 1 KCs (2.5 pts) · Podcast Discussion (3 pts) — Begin developing assigned Ethical Scenario
Week 2 6/8/2026 (Mon)	Module 02 opens — Effective Treatment, Clients & ABA's Critics Section 2.0 (19 codes) · Engages autistic self-advocacy critique	— Watch Lecture Module 2 (21:44, 8 KCs) — Video: Cody Morris on Assent (Behavioral Observations S313) + Edpuzzle
Week 2 6/9–6/13/2026	Required external resources	— Podcast: Inside the BACB — Assent & Effective Treatment — Podcast: Behavioral Observations — Practical-Functional Approach & Assent Withdrawal — Reading: Morris, Detrick, & Peterson (2021) — Participant Assent — Reading: Sandoval-Norton, Shkedy, & Shkedy (2019) — How Much Compliance Is Too Much
Week 2	Module 02 closes — All M02 assignments due 11:59 PM	— Decision Lab 2 — Mason scenario (5 pts) · Toolkit 2 — Assent Monitoring Protocol (2 pts) · Lecture Module 2 KCs (2.5 pts) · Critique

6/14/2026 (Sun)		Engagement Discussion (3 pts) — Continue developing Ethical Scenario
Week 3 6/15/2026 (Mon)	Module 03 opens — Clients, Supervision & the Digital Practitioner Sections 3.0 (16 codes) + 4.0 (12 codes) + supervision-era social media + AI/telehealth	— Watch Lecture Module 3 (16:45, 8 KCs) — Video: Inside the BACB Ep. 21 — Carr & Sellers on Section 4 Supervision + Edpuzzle — Video: ABA Inside Track Ep. 51 — Ethics and Social Media + Edpuzzle — Video: Hi Rasmus — Ethical Behavior Analysis in the Age of AI + Edpuzzle
Week 3 6/16–6/18/2026	Required external resources	— Podcast: Inside the BACB — Sections 4.0 + 5.0 in Practice — Reading: Sellers, LeBlanc & Valentino (2016) — Recommendations for Supervision of Trainees — Reading: O'Leary et al. (2017) — Blurred Lines: Ethical Implications of Social Media for Behavior Analysts — Reading: AI in Behavior-Analytic Practice — Ethical Considerations (2024)
6/19/2026 (Fri)	No class observance — Juneteenth	—
Week 3 6/21/2026 (Sun)	Module 03 closes — All M03 assignments due 11:59 PM (HEAVIEST WEEK)	— Decision Lab 3 — Maya / TikTok / AI Notes (5 pts) · Toolkit 3 — Social Media + Digital Practice Policy (2 pts) · Lecture Module 3 KCs (2.5 pts) · Restraint Engagement Position Video (3 pts) — FINAL Ethical Scenarios Video Presentation + 2 Peer Reviews — CAPSTONE (10 pts)
Week 4 6/22/2026 (Mon)	Module 04 opens — Public Statements, Research & Enforcement: Becoming an Ethical BA Sections 5.0 (11 codes) + 6.0 (11 codes) + Code-Enforcement Procedures	— Watch Lecture Module 4 (16:42, 8 KCs) — BACB Annual Summary of Ethics Violations (latest year) — Pick Five Notices of Disciplinary Action across categories (from BACB site)
Week 4 6/23–6/27/2026	Required external resources	— Podcast: Inside the BACB — Section 6.0 + Code-Enforcement Procedures — Optional: Brodhead, Cox, & Quigley (2018) — Practical Ethics for Effective Treatment of ASD — Practitioner Interview (schedule and conduct this week)
Week 4	Module 04 closes — All M04	— Decision Lab 4 — Dr. Chen / Retroactive Research (5 pts) · Lecture Module 4 KCs (2.5 pts)

6/28/2026 (Sun)	assignments due 11:59 PM	· Disciplinary Patterns Discussion (3 pts) · Practitioner Interview Report — CAPSTONE (4 pts) — Toolkit 4 — Your Personal Code of Practice — CAPSTONE (10 pts)
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Note: The schedule is tentative. The instructor reserves the right to adjust topics, due dates, or resources to individualize instruction. Any changes will be announced via Brightspace and reflected on the course site.